the finance director of Tata Sons. It also had the members of the GEO and representatives of financial institutions.

The BRCs acted as a link between the promoter and the group companies. Ratan underscored its importance stating that Tata Sons had to 'often consider investments in terms of the growth and direction of a particular company'. Within this overarching goal, its focus was more on 'trying to make a company more profitable, more productive'. The BRC prevented 'proliferation in the same businesses in other companies'. It became a 'catalyst' and played a critical role in getting the group companies ready for a competitive environment, says Raju Bhinge.

Initially BRCs were established for twelve companies—TISCO, TELCO, Tata Chemicals, Tata Electric Companies, TCS/Tata Infotech (jointly), ACC, Tata Tea/Consolidated Coffee, Indian Hotels, Voltas, the Forbes group of companies, Titan and Rallis. By 2002, two more were set up.

As part of the BRC process, Tata Sons prescribed a 'fairly extensive check list' of what they expected the various group companies to do, required companies to prepare themselves to face competition and make them 'endeavour to benchmark' themselves 'against others in that business and rate itself'. This also included group companies presenting themselves in 'terms of profitability and return on capital employed against some goals that [had] been set by the group'. Initially, the BRCs were viewed with some suspicion by the group companies, but Ratan clarified that in case of a difference of opinion between the BRCs and the management of operating companies, the BRCs did not override the management, but only acted as collaborators.

The BRCs became one of the most important components of the restructuring initiatives. According to Ratan, '[The] BRC process forced them [the group companies] to look very critically at their businesses, in terms of issues like where they are going, will they be globally competitive, benchmarking against the best, and so on. Many of them had never done that before.'

The Group Corporate Centre

As the twenty-first century dawned, Ratan had achieved much of what he had set out to do. He had accomplished his initial objective of ensuring the group's survival, which many in 1991 had feared he would fail trying. Now,